

IT IS TIME FOR RENEWAL

TEXT: 2 Chronicles 33:9-13 (NKJV)

“Manasseh seduced Judah and the inhabitants of Jerusalem to do more evil than the nations whom the Lord had destroyed before the children of Israel. ¹⁰ And the Lord spoke to Manasseh and his people, but they would not listen. ¹¹ Therefore the Lord brought upon them the captains of the army of the king of Assyria, who took Manasseh with hooks, bound him with bronze fetters, and carried him off to Babylon. ¹² Now when he was in affliction, he implored the Lord his God, and humbled himself greatly before the God of his fathers, ¹³ and prayed to Him; and He received his entreaty, heard his supplication, and brought him back to Jerusalem into his kingdom. Then Manasseh knew that the Lord was God.”

INTRO: America needs renewal... CT needs renewal... ALL of us need renewal! In just a few weeks we will host the Empowerment Conference, which is our ministers conference and annual church revival. In an effort to get us ready to be renewed and revived during that time, over the next few weeks we are going to talk about five types of renewal:

- Personal renewal...
- Relational renewal...
- Missional renewal...
- Cultural renewal...
- Structural renewal...

As a basis for our study concerning renewal, I would like to use the Old Testament character of Manasseh, which can be found in 2 Chronicles.

Manasseh, the son of Hezekiah, was the thirteenth king of the Southern Kingdom. Not only was his 55-year-reign, the longest of any king in the history of the Israelites, but he also had the distinction of being the worst king

that Judah ever had. During his reign he reversed every good thing his father Hezekiah had done. He not only took the nation in a bad direction; he took the nation much further into idolatry than it was when his father began to reign decades earlier.

God became so incensed with Manasseh and his godless reign and lifestyle, that he allowed Manasseh to be captured and carried off to Babylon where he was persecuted. While in Babylon, Manasseh repented before the Lord and the Lord brought him out of captivity.

Manasseh experienced personal renewal and as a result, Israel experienced renewal as well. I want to point out that repentance is the common denominator of all renewal. America needs renewal – Renewal will only come if there is true repentance. 2 Chronicles 7:14 (NKJV) ***“If My people who are called by My name will humble themselves, and pray and seek My face, and turn from their wicked ways, then I***

will hear from heaven, and will forgive their sin and heal their land.”

Though few, if any, would have expected it, Manasseh changed in a good way. (Susan has a saying – *“People can change – But not much.”*)
2 Chronicles 33:12 ***“In his distress he sought the favor of the Lord his God and humbled himself greatly before the God of his ancestors. And when he prayed to him. The Lord was moved by his entreaty and listened to his plea; so he brought him back to Jerusalem and to his kingdom. Then Manasseh knew that the Lord is God.”***

Manasseh then proceeded to remove idolatry and lead a spiritual renewal by making positive changes:

- He repented... (This is always the first step to renewal – Repentance is not just saying, *“I am sorry”*, it is being sorry with the corresponding action of real-life change)

- He humbled himself... (Humility is an essential part of renewal – ***“God resists the proud but gives grace to the humble.”***)
- He prayed... (When we stop praying - We start sinning – When we start praying - We stop sinning)
- He tore down pagan altars... (Renewal causes us to devalue what we once valued -And value what we once devalued)
- He repaired the altar of the Lord... (The altar is always important to those who are seeking renewal _Elijah did this on Mt. Carmel)
- He offered peace offerings to the Lord... (We can’t offer a peace offering to the Lord if we continue doing the things that offend Him)
- He offered thank offerings to the Lord... (Worship becomes extremely important to those who are seeking renewal)
- He commanded the people to serve Jehovah exclusively... (Those who are serious about renewal will not only put God in first place -

They will not permit any other God's in their orbit)

Manasseh's renewal began as does all renewal... With...

PERSONAL RENEWAL

While in Babylon, in the hands of his persecutors Manasseh turned his heart to the Lord. All personal renewal starts with the heart.

If we need a personal renewal, that means we need to fall in love with Jesus again. When we do that — all of a sudden, it's not about religion and rituals; it's about a relationship with Jesus.

Those who fall in love with Jesus and experience renewal will be characterized by:

- Powerful living... (Spirit-filled living – ***“If we walk in the Spirit we will not fulfill the lusts of the flesh.”*** – If our personal life is suspect that is a pretty good sign that we need renewal)

- Private prayer... (Praying people are Godly people – Do you have a prayer life? What time do you pray? If you can't tell me what time you pray I'm going to say you don't have a prayer life – It is absolutely certain that if we don't have a prayer life, renewal is on the menu for us)
- Personal Bible study... (Do you have a systematic pattern of Bible study? Do you have family devotions? If we are not in the Word every day, we are certainly weak in our walk, which means we need renewal – Walk Through The Word – Patreon)
- Public worship... (Does every little thing keep us from public worship? If so, we need renewal – ***“Forsake not the assembling of yourselves together, as the manner of some is, and so much more as you see the day approaching.”***)
- Plentiful giving... (Are we stingy or generous? This is a sure test for the need for renewal – Generosity vs. Compliance)

- Purposeful witnessing... (Are we telling anyone about Jesus? If not, we need renewal – Renewal will set us to talking about Jesus again)
- Praise-filled joy... (Renewed people are joyful people – Those who need renewal are sad sacks)

Personal renewal changes everything! Just as a baby changes everything, renewal changes everything. When Manasseh experienced personal renewal, it affected every part of his life, both personal and professional.

END OF SERMON #1

RELATIONAL RENEWAL

2 Chronicles 33:9-13 (NKJV) “*Manasseh seduced Judah and the inhabitants of Jerusalem to do more evil than the nations whom the Lord had destroyed before the children of Israel.* ¹⁰ *And the Lord spoke to*

Manasseh and his people, but they would not listen. ¹¹ Therefore the Lord brought upon them the captains of the army of the king of Assyria, who took Manasseh with hooks, bound him with bronze fetters, and carried him off to Babylon. ¹² Now when he was in affliction, he implored the Lord his God, and humbled himself greatly before the God of his fathers, ¹³ and prayed to Him; and He received his entreaty, heard his supplication, and brought him back to Jerusalem into his kingdom. Then Manasseh knew that the Lord was God.”

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that Judah ever had. During his reign he reversed every good thing his father Hezekiah had done. He not only took the nation in a bad direction; he took the nation much further into idolatry than it was when his father began to reign decades earlier.

God became so incensed with Manasseh and his godless reign and lifestyle, that he allowed Manasseh to be captured and carried off to Babylon where he was persecuted. While in Babylon, Manasseh repented before the Lord and the Lord brought him out of captivity.

Manasseh experienced renewal and as a result, Israel experienced renewal as well. I want to point out that repentance is the common denominator of all renewal. America needs renewal – Renewal will only come if there is true repentance. 2 Chronicles 7:14 (NKJV) ***“If My people who are called by My name will humble themselves, and pray and seek My face, and turn from their wicked ways, then I***

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Last week we talked about personal renewal. When we get right with God, we will get right with others.

Jesus told us to love God with all of our heart and then love others as ourselves. All of us have struggled with the breaking of relationships and battle lines being drawn. God is not about

division; He is about renewal. ***“Blessed are the peacemakers for they shall be called the children of God.”*** (Like Father – Like children)
(Discuss the difference between a peacekeeper and a peacemaker)

How do we know when there has been a relational renewal? Jesus said, ***“They will know that you have passed from death to life because you love one another.”***

Signs of relational renewal:

- Gossip will cease...
- Wishing harm will no longer be on the agenda...
- Acts of kindness will be forthcoming...
- People will want to spend time together...
- Suddenly, we want to be in community together... (Life Groups)

Sadly, nowhere in society have the lines been more clearly drawn between people groups than in the church:

- Liberal vs. conservative...
- One denomination vs. another denomination...
- Pentecostals vs. non-Pentecostal...
- Catholic vs. protestant...
- Evangelicals vs. everyone else...
- Black vs. white...
- Hispanics vs. blacks...

The world must look at us and think, “*Why would I want to go to church, I have enough brokenness and dysfunction as it is.*”

Manasseh received from His father a nation that served the Lord and worked together. Over his 55-year-reign he managed to destroy everything his father had built, and surrendered his kingdom to the Assyrians.

In Babylon God turned his heart and he had relational renewal so that God was able to place him back on the throne of Judah.

We need relational renewal – relational renewal brings us together. If we would get together, we could become the answer to Jesus’ one and only prayer request – ***“Father, I pray that You would make them one.”*** The reason Jesus was so intent on us becoming one is that more can be done in a group, than everyone can do singlehandedly. Leviticus 26:8 ***“Five of you shall chase a hundred, and a hundred of you shall chase ten thousand.”*** If one extrapolates the effect created by ***“Five chasing a hundred”*** it stands to reason that one hundred can chase two thousand. Yet the Bible says ***“A hundred of you can put ten thousand to flight!”***

Because of the synergy created by fighting together, the ability of a person to produce, rises from a ratio of one-to-twenty, to one-to-one hundred! We are better together than we are apart! We need relational renewal!

END OF SERMON #2

MISSIONAL RENEWAL

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Missional renewal is when we rediscover what God wants us to do. When missional renewal occurs, we give up on our ideas and embrace His ideas. It is at this point that we realize, we are a part of something bigger than any one of us could accomplish solo.

While Manasseh was in Babylon, he experienced missional renewal. Pre-Babylon Manasseh had a very secular worldview. Post-Babylon he had a God worldview. When he had a missional renewal he made some major reversals:

- He followed a different God...
- He governed differently...
- He exercised justice differently...
- The results of his reign were different...

When we experience missional renewal, we begin to realize we have a kingdom assignment. John Wesley said, “*Give me 100 men who fear*

nothing but sin and desire nothing but God, and I will shake the world.”

I think there is a mammoth knowledge gap in the church. We seem to think we are here to serve our families and ourselves, but God has placed us here to accomplish a Kingdom purpose. In accomplishing the Kingdom purpose, we take care of ourselves and our families, but the scope of what we do becomes broadened into a Kingdom centered effort.

When we embrace missional renewal everything changes:

- We go from living self-centered lives; to having a biblical worldview...
- We go from thinking first of self; to thinking of how we can have an impact on culture...
- We go from prioritizing everything on how our futures will be affected; to considering the eternal impact...

- We go from laying up an overabundance of treasure on temporal things; to making Kingdom investments...

What is your missional purpose?

Do you have one?

If not, are you willing to consider a missional renewal?

END OF SEMON #3

CULTURAL RENEWAL

2 Chronicles 33:9-13 (NKJV) “*Manasseh seduced Judah and the inhabitants of Jerusalem to do more evil than the nations whom the Lord had destroyed before the children of Israel.* ¹⁰ *And the Lord spoke to Manasseh and his people, but they would not listen.* ¹¹ *Therefore the Lord brought upon them the captains of the army of the king of Assyria, who took Manasseh with hooks, bound him with bronze fetters, and carried him off to Babylon.* ¹² *Now when he was in*

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We have talked about:

- Personal Renewal...
- Relational Renewal...
- Missional Renewal...

Today we are going to talk about Cultural Renewal and Structural Renewal.

In the first part of his reign, Manasseh created a cultural decline. In fact, he created a paradigm that allowed the culture to go over the cliff!

Look at the effects of this cultural shift:

- Manasseh every good thing his father Hezekiah had accomplished...
- Manasseh ALLOWED idolatrous worship as if the graven images were the one that had delivered Israel...
- Every evil, satanic thing, that goes with the worship of idols was being practiced openly...
- This cultural shift was to blame for Judah falling to the Assyrians...

Sadly, America is in the exact same place that Judah was in at the time of their captivity. And the church just sits idly by! It is time for the church to wake up and rise up! The culture is not supposed to dictate to the church how things are going to be done, the church is supposed to establish culture!

Think of this – I know this covid virus is real and a lot of people have been sick and a lot of people have died. Since January 2020 4,025,000

People have tested positive and 144,000 People (Supposedly) have died from the virus:

- During this same time period, 460,000 babies have been aborted in the United States... (This is more than three times more deaths than Covid)
- During this same time period, 354,400 people have died from heart disease in the United States... (Two and a half times more deaths than Covid)
- During this same time period, 332,330 people have died of cancer in the United States... (Almost two and a half times more than Covid)
- 155,000 alcohol and drug related deaths occur in the United States per year... (As many as Covid)

Yet, we follow the path that liberal leaders have chosen for us to travel, just like sheep being led to the slaughter.

- I believe that black lives matter – Absolutely!
- I believe Hispanic lives matter...
- I believe Asian lives matter...
- I believe Latino lives matter...
- I believe American Indian lives matter...
- I believe Islander lives matter...
- I believe White lives matter...
- I believe ALL lives matter...

What I don't believe in, is the agenda behind Black Lives Matter: (the following is from the Black Lives Matter website)

- *We disrupt the Western-prescribed nuclear family structure requirement by supporting each other as extended families and “villages” that collectively care for one another, especially our children, to the degree that mothers, parents, and children are comfortable.*
- *We make space for transgender brothers and sisters to participate and lead.*

- *We are self-reflexive and do the work required to dismantle cisgender privilege and uplift Black trans folk, especially Black trans women who continue to be disproportionately impacted by trans-antagonistic violence.*
- *We foster a queer-affirming network. When we gather, we do so with the intention of freeing ourselves from the tight grip of heteronormative thinking, or rather, the belief that all in the world are heterosexual (unless s/he or they disclose otherwise).*
- I believe in the right to protest – I don't believe in the right to loot...
- I believe in the right to speak freely – I don't believe in the right to steal other peoples possessions...
- I believe in the right to bear arms – I don't believe in the right to trespass on the property of others...

- I believe in the right to be wrong – I don't believe in the right to silence the majority for the pleasure of a few...

If the church fails to recognize what the agenda of left-wing radicals is all about and respond accordingly in the next three months, we will lose the cultural battle for the heart and soul of America. If we lose this battle it will have disastrous consequences for at least a hundred years, if the change is not altogether permanent.

It is time for cultural renewal! Cultural renewal will be driven by the church or it will not happen at all. ***“Judgment must first begin at the house of God.”***

How do we bring about cultural renewal?

- Speak out against the wrongs of the society...
- Vote according to the principles of the Word of God...

- Raise our families according to Godly principles...
- Pray for the intervention of God in the affairs of man... 2 Chronicles 7:14 ***“If My people who are called by My name will humble themselves and pray, I will hear from heaven, forgive their sin and heal their land.”*** (Tuesday night prayer)

When these things start happening, suddenly we begin to impact the culture. We will go from an inward turned focus (bless my four and no more), to an outward focused people. When this happens, we begin to affect the destinies of entire family lines.

At this point the church will mobilize outside the four walls and begin to impact lives in every sphere of influence.

Are you ready for cultural renewal? Really ready?

- Take a stand... (Get your voice back)

- Fade the heat... (It will be unpleasant – Jesus said, “*They hated me, they are going to hate you too!*”)
- Be consistent... (Stay the course – In 1953 coach John Thomas said, “*When the going gets tough – The tough get going.*”)
- Influence others... (Leverage the influence you have to the best of your ability)